

Dirty Air, Unequal Burden: Houston's Ship Channel Communities Deserve Clean Air

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A child should not have to think about the quality of the air before he goes outside. A grandmother should not have to think about whether the odor coming from the nearby plant is a sign of another chemical release. However, for families living right next to the Houston Ship Channel, pollution is not an abstract climate issue or a distant article in the newspaper. Pollution is represented by the air that is inhaled into their lungs, the smell that exists outside their children's school, and the risk that lingers over their homes.

The Houston Ship Channel has been referred to as an important aspect for economic development, however, economic growth must also consider human health and well being. Low-income, Hispanic, and African American families who live near industrial sites have suffered the weight of carrying a large share of the toxic emissions produced by these industries compared to wealthier residents located further from the source of pollution. Without providing every resident the opportunity to prosper, Houston cannot claim to be a city of opportunity when certain communities are treated more like sacrifice zones.

It's impossible not to notice the statistics behind this issue. An Air Alliance Houston report indicated that there were an estimated total of 1,735 industrial emissions incidents in Harris County between 2017 and 2024, with more than 49 million pounds of air pollutants emitted via faulty equipment, fires, explosions, equipment failure and many other means. ([Air Alliance Houston](#)) These incidents have occurred numerous times over the past eight years, which clearly shows that the system permitting dangerous air pollution to enter the atmosphere continues to fail to protect people living in close proximity to these facilities.

Manchester is one of the most predominant Latino neighborhoods located next to the Ship Channel. The residents in these neighborhoods live in close proximity to refineries, chemical manufacturing facilities, highways, and areas that are at high risk of flooding. Pollution in neighborhoods such as Manchester and Pleasantville is compounded by a lack of access to infrastructure, limited access to health care resources, high prevalence of risky flood areas, and an absence of political representation. There have been documented studies conducted on the air quality in the region surrounding the Ship Channel that showed serious concerns regarding environmental justice due to exposure of hazardous pollutants like benzene and 1-3 butadiene, which are both known to have significant implications for human health. ([HERO](#))

Houston's air quality issue is everywhere in the city. According to the American Lung Association's 2026 "State of the Air" report, the Houston metro area was rated 6th worst in the U.S. for ozone pollution, and Harris County received an "F" as an overall grade. Additionally, they reported that the average number of unhealthy ozone days in Harris County is 43.3 days per year. ([American Lung Association](#)) For children, older adults, and people suffering from asthma or other respiratory illnesses, these statistics are much more than just statistics, but

mean frequent coughing, increased use of inhalers, more sick days from school and more trips to the emergency room.

Many business owners believe that stricter pollution restrictions will damage their businesses, or hinder their economies from growing. However, saying such a thing does not take into consideration the costs being incurred every day by families living near polluted areas. A healthy economy does not require unclean air! Businesses should be able to make a profit without forcing nearby residents to bear the medical, emotional, and environmental costs of unsafe and unsustainable practices.

Because economic growth and clean air should not be treated as opposites, Houston's city leaders should not have to choose between jobs and clean air. The Houston City Council should enforce stronger regulations and create a clear residential air safety plan for communities near the Houston Ship Channel, including Manchester, Pleasantville, and Galena Park. The plan should include real-time air monitoring near schools, parks, community centers, and homes, pollution alerts in English and Spanish, and an online system for residents to track chemicals in their communities.

The City of Houston should collaborate with the following government entities: Harris County Pollution Control, Harris County Public Health, and The Texas Commission on Environmental Quality (TCEQ). The city needs cooperation from these entities in order to increase the number of inspections of facilities that have repeated violations. Penalties should be stronger than just warnings or fines for facilities that repeatedly violate the law. City of Houston officials need to advocate for stricter local permitting requirements, easy access to emergency preparedness plans and quick public notification when there is an industrial accident.

Above all, communities affected by the Ship Channel should be represented as decision-makers during the planning process. People who live close to the Ship Channel are more familiar with the air pollution, headaches, flaring and feeling unsafe than anyone else involved in the process. As such, any plan must include providing community meetings to all affected neighbourhoods, access to translators, and opportunity for direct input from residents prior to the issuance of new permits or expansions.

Houston may take years to address the impacts of its pollutants, but that doesn't mean it must act like they are normal. Houston has a responsibility to protect the health of its citizens. The communities surrounding the Ship Channel should not continue to bear the burdens caused by Houston's industrial growth. People living near the ship channel should be the top priority when providing protection for their health and safety.